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Before the end of this month, the intermittent dynamite blasts that have echoed deep inside a mountain on Vancouver Island will be replaced by the steady rumble and hum of machinery in production.

Busy little **Cowichan Copper** will be rolling on its four-year contract to supply some $20 million in copper concentrates to the even busier **Japanese.**

The start-up will be a tribute to **Oswood G. "Ozzie" MacDonald,** a tenacious character who usually accomplishes what he sets out to do.

Five years ago, most people just laughed when MacDonald said he was going to put the old **Blue Grouse** mine at **Cowichan Lake** into production. But he cornered a three-year contract with the Japanese, dug and scraped 14 million pounds of copper and 70,000 ounces of silver from the island property, worth about $5 million.

When further development of the mine proved uneconomic, Ozzie looked around for something else.

He hit on the **Sunro Mines,** a combination of the **Sunloch** and **Gabbro** properties, owned 85 per cent by **Consolidated Mining & Smelting** and 15 per cent by **Noranda.**

Over the years about $1.5 million had been spent on the claims proving up 974,000 tons of 1.8 per cent copper. For reasons of their own the majors never put Sunro into production and were happy to give MacDonald a 10-year lease with further extensions to 20 years.

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MacDonald knew it would be a costly job to move ore 7,000 feet to the portal entrance and build a mill and powerhouse on the edge of the Jordan River canyon.

Then there would be the expensive job of constructing a breakwater and deepsea dock in the teeth of the mighty **Pacific** that pounds ceaselessly on the southwestern tip of the island.

Ozzie decided to put the milling operation underground, right beside the ore. Rather than fight the Pacific, he would truck the concentrates 58 miles, through **Sooke** and over the **Malahat,** to Cowichan's existing dock at Hatch Point near Duncan on the east side of the island.

MacDonald ran into problems with the "experts" on the underground operation but he persisted. Working under mine manager **J. R. Billingsley,** Cowichan crews blasted out the mill site almost 1½ miles into the mountain. It would have cost 65 cents a cubic foot to excavate if the job had been contracted. Billingsley did it for 46 cents a foot, MacDonald says.

The 200-foot-long cavern houses the whole operation. Tailings are pumped out and deposited at tidewater.

With his contract from **Mitsui & Company,** MacDonald borrowed $1.2 million from the Japanese and his bank to make a mine out of Sunro.

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The first shipload of 1,000 tons of concentrates will move to Japan April 25. The second, of 2,500 tons, will be picked up May 10 and the third, 3,000 tons, will go out on June 25.

Within three months of the start-up MacDonald expects to be putting 1,500 tons of ore through the mill each day.

At the official opening on May 15, the underground operation will be festooned with colorful Japanese lanterns. Visitors will be able to stroll along the catwalk, which runs the full length of the cavern, and watch the whole process.

Even by under-estimating ore grade by 10 per cent and over-estimating costs by a like amount, MacDonald figures all liabilities will be cleared off within a year. Then, Cowichan can start building up some badly-needed working capital and explore the other 12, low-grade copper zones on the property.

On known reserves it is figured the mine has a six-year life. But Optimistic Ozzie is counting on being in production a lot longer than that.

Well, what about dividends on the 2.5 million issued shares? MacDonald thinks directors can start figuring on them after the third year.

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